

Cambridge-Isanti Soccer Club

Recreational Referee Handbook

This handbook is intended to guide new and returning referees on how to confidently officiate games in the CISC recreational soccer program.

General Recreational Rules

- All players must wear shin guards and either soccer cleats or tennis shoes.
- Substitutions are unlimited. Substitutions can be made at any stoppage and must be signaled for by the coach and allowed by the referee.
- If the ball goes out of bounds over the end line and was last touched by the defending team, the offensive team gets a corner kick. If the defending team last touched it, a goal kick is awarded. The opposing team must be behind the halfway line for goal kicks at U6-U8 levels.
- If the ball goes out of bounds over the sideline, the restart is a throw-in. At U4 and U6, referees may allow re-dos for improper throws.
- A hand ball results in an indirect free kick for the opposing team, unless it's a deliberate hand ball which may result in a direct kick or penalty kick.
- Spectators must sit on the opposite side of the field from players and coaches.
- If teams are short players, they may borrow players from the other team or combine teams for a scrimmage.

Rules by Age Group

U4

- Ball Size: 3
- Players: 4 vs 4 (no goalie)
- Halves: 10 minutes
- Substitutions: Unlimited, managed by coaches
- Coaches act as referees and are allowed on the field to assist players
- Throw-ins: May be kicked or thrown in and redos are allowed
- Goal kicks and corner kicks follow simplified format

U5/U6

- Ball Size: 3
- Players: 6 vs 6 (including goalie)
- Halves: 15 minutes
- Coaches are allowed on the field to assist players
- Throw-ins: Redo allowed for first infraction
- Referees manage substitutions and enforce rules
- Goal kicks: Opponents must retreat behind halfway line
- No offside rule enforced

U7/U8

- Ball Size: 3
- Players: 6 vs 6 (including goalie)
- Halves: 20 minutes
- Throw-ins: Redo allowed for first infraction
- Goal kicks and corner kicks follow standard rules
- Referees should allow substitutions at natural stoppages
- No offside rule enforced

U9/U10

- Ball Size: 4
- Players: 7 vs 7 (including goalie)
- Halves: 25 minutes
- Throw-ins: Redo allowed for first infraction
- Goal kicks and corner kicks follow standard rules
- Substitutions allowed at stoppages, with referee approval
- No heading allowed
- No slide tackling
- Offside rule is enforced
- Penalty kicks awarded for fouls inside the penalty box

Referee Responsibilities & Expectations

Referees are the first impression that many players and parents have with the game. Your professionalism, appearance, and attitude help shape a fun and safe playing environment for all.

Please make sure you are properly equipped:

- CISC ref shirt and whistle (provided)
- Stopwatch (available to check out if needed)
- No cell phones allowed on the field during matches
- Bring your own water bottle

Pregame:

- Arrive 15 minutes early to check in and assist coaches
- Confirm all players are wearing shin guards and correct footwear
- No jewelry is allowed (earrings must be removed or taped)
- Check goal and field setup

During the Game:

- Keep games on time; use your watch and whistle
- Allow substitutions at any stoppage
- Signal goals and fouls clearly and confidently
- Blow your whistle loud enough for both teams to hear
- Keep a fun, safe, and positive attitude

Post-Game:

- Thank coaches and players
- Return equipment if borrowed
- Report any issues to CISC board or Ref Coordinator

Game Situations and Rules to Know

a. Out of Bounds

When the ball FULLY crosses the out-of-bounds line—either on the sideline or the end line—you must clearly communicate what happened using your voice, whistle, and arm signals.

- Sideline: Award a throw-in to the team that did NOT touch it last.
- End line: Award either a goal kick or corner kick.

b. Substitutions

Allowed at any stoppage in play. Unlimited in number. Ensure teams are ready before resuming.

c. Hand Ball

- Deliberate hand ball = foul. Restart with indirect free kick or penalty kick if inside the box at U10+.
- Goalkeeper may use hands only inside their own goal box.
- Cannot pick up a ball passed to them by a teammate's feet.

d. Play On / Advantage

If a foul occurs but the opposing team retains the ball and has an opportunity, say "Advantage!" and let play continue.

e. Common Fouls

Include tripping, pushing, charging, striking, and obstruction.

f. Indirect vs Direct Kicks

- All free kicks are indirect (unless it's a penalty kick in U10). Indirect kicks must touch another player before scoring.

g. Goals

- Blow whistle and point to the center circle when a goal is scored.
- Retrieve and place the ball at midfield.

h. Time-Outs

- There are NO time-outs in soccer, unless called by the referee for injury.

i. Heading

- Not allowed under age 12. Results in indirect kick for the other team.

j. Throw-Ins

- Must be thrown over the head with both feet on the ground.
- U4–U8: One redo allowed.

k. Slide Tackling

- Not allowed in rec league. If it happens, stop play and speak to the player. Repeat = notify coach and ask player to sit out for a break.

l. Goal Kicks and Corner Kicks

- **Goal Kick:** When the ball goes out of bounds past the end line and was last touched by the opposing team, place the ball a few yards in front of the goal. The team that last defended the goal kicks it back into play. Opponents should move back and give space (U10 retreats behind build-out line).
- **Corner Kick:** If the ball goes out of bounds past the end line and was last touched by the defending team, the other team gets to kick from the corner of the field near where the ball went out.

Referees should focus more on getting the ball back into play quickly than on enforcing perfect placement or technique at this age.